Lesson 20 material: Enumerative Paragraphs 1: Focus, Topic Sentence, Supporting Ideas and Conclusion

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 2: Sentences and Paragraph Types · American History

Unit 4 Enumerative Paragraphs (part I-V)

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Original page, with audio and online exercises: https://harpercollege.pressbooks.pub/academic-writing-skills/chapter/unit-4enumerative-paragraphs/
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Unit 4 Enumerative Paragraphs

Learning Objectives

1. To understand what an enumerative paragraph focuses on
2. To learn to write topic sentences, supporting sentences with details, conclusion, and transitions in enumerative paragraphs through multiple examples
3. To apply the writing process to plan and write enumerative paragraphs

I. Warm-up

(Picture: washing machines and dryers in a laundromat)

washing machines and dryers in a laundromat

Read Paragraph “Public Laundromats in the U.S.A.” and do the activities that follow.

Public Laundromats in the U.S.A.

When I moved to Chicago, I was shocked because I had to use a public laundromat. Most people living in the apartments do not have their own washer and dryer, but I think this situation creates some problems for them. The transportation of dirty linen and clothes is the first problem. People need to collect everything and go down to the apartment basement where the machines are. Sometimes, they have to drive to the nearest laundromat if all washing machines are occupied by their neighbors. They may wait even half a day for a free washer or dryer. The second problem is having the exact change. Each washing costs $2.75 to $3.50. People need to frequently collect quarters or change money in the bank. The problems do not end here. The biggest problem of using public laundromats is hygiene. No one knows what kind of things people have washed in the same machines: underwear, linen, cloth diapers, even shoes. One day, while waiting for an available washer, I decided to take out a neighbor’s laundry from the washing machine because the laundry had been there for a long time. When I did this, I felt sorry and angry. I found different things which could not be washed together because it was not hygienic to do so. Of course, for eight months in America, I had to use the public laundromat more than a few times because I did not have another choice. Imagine my happiness and relief[1] when I finally bought my own first washing machine!

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1. Color code the paragraph:

Title – ***pink*** Topic sentence – ***red*** Supporting sentences – ***green***

Supporting details – ***blue*** Transitions – ***yellow*** Concluding sentence(s) – ***red***

2. Discuss:

- Have you had similar experiences or witnessed similar situations as described in this paragraph?
- Does the writer focus on telling a story, arguing for a controversial[2] issue, or listing points to explain an idea?
- What types of supporting ideas and details are used to explain the main idea?
- Does the paragraph have unity?
- What information is included in the conclusion?
- Is the paragraph complete?
- Is the title centered on the topic line? Is the first sentence indented?
- What do you like about this paragraph?
- How would you improve the paragraph?
- If you could ask the writer a question, what would you ask?

II. Focus of Enumerative Paragraphs

To enumerate is to list or to count. It focuses on explaining some points to support a main idea. You have actually studied many enumerative paragraphs in Unit 2 and Unit 3, in addition to Paragraph "Public Laundromats in the U.S.A." above.

- Unit 2 The Benefits of NSNT for Me
- Unit 3 Missing My Childhood Days
- Unit 3 Difficulties in English Writing
- Unit 3 My Special Place
- Unit 3 Good Roommates
- Unit 3 The Best Exercise
- Unit 3 Unleashed Dogs
- Unit 3 Three Benefits of Online Classes for College Students

Review those paragraphs for ideas, organization, language use, and format. In this unit, you are going to learn from more examples and to write your own enumerative paragraphs. Here are some more topics typical[3] of enumerative paragraphs:

- Communication barriers[4] among family members
- Characteristics of a good boss
- Benefits of owning a dog
- Reasons for coming to the U.S.
- Advice to new international students

III. Topic Sentence in Enumerative Paragraphs

EXERCISE

♠♠ Click here to review topic sentences from Unit 3 Parts and Characteristics of a Good Paragraph: A topic sentence shows the main idea of a paragraph. It usually appears in the beginning of a paragraph. A good topic sentence includes the topic, controlling idea, and optional predictors. The controlling idea is the writer's opinion or feeling about the topic. A topic sentence must be a complete sentence (subject + verb). A topic sentence cannot be a question, an announcement, or a fact.

For detailed explanations and examples of topic sentences, open Unit 3 here.

The same topic can produce many different topic sentences if the controlling idea is changed. Of course, the paragraph will be different as a result. This shows that you have the flexibility to decide on your focus based on your interests. **Write from your heart!**

Study the following topic sentences and discuss how writers focus on different areas of the same topic. You will notice that some topic sentences are more formal/academic in nature and some are more personal.

Topics	Topic sentences with different controlling ideas	
communication barriers among family members	Three subjects often cause disagreement between teenagers and their parents.	I have learned to improve communication with my siblings in three areas: timing, topic, and tone.
characteristics of a good boss	A good boss usually displays the following characteristics: understanding, flexibility[5], and humility[6].	I love my former boss for his encouragement, fairness, and generosity[7].
benefits of owning a dog	There are thee benefits to owning a dog.	My neighbor's puppy Skippy has brought much joy to my family.
Reasons for coming to the U.S.	Pursuing freedom in religion, speech, and political affiliation is the main reason why many people choose to immigrate to the U.S.	My family came to the U.S. because we wished for good economic prospects[8], equal educational opportunities, and a multicultural environment.

Exercise 1. Try different controlling ideas and write at least two different topic sentences with each of the following topics.

***Example**:*

Advice to new international students

Topic sentence 1: New international students will adapt to a new environment better if they prepare themselves well before leaving their native country.

Topic sentence 2: Finding a caring host family, working closely with professors and counsellors, and joining student clubs are the best ways for new international students to succeed.

1. Ways to improve grades in this writing class

2. Advantages of technology for elderly people
3. Disadvantages of technology for young children
4. The best kitchen appliance for you
5. Your least favorite store

IV. Supporting Ideas in Enumerative Paragraphs

EXERCISE

♠♠ Click here to review supporting sentences from Unit 3 Parts and Characteristics of a Good Paragraph: To ensure good, relevant support: Ask a question about the controlling idea in the topic sentence. Your answer could be the basis for supporting ideas. Make an outline. Delete irrelevant and repetitive ideas. Remember the "Hamburger Way". Use facts, explanations, examples, quotes, etc. to make the paragraph interesting.

For detailed explanations and examples of supporting sentences, open Unit 3 here.

In an enumerative paragraph, the supporting ideas follow a logical order. The most important point is usually listed last. Study the paragraph below and discuss how the writer uses different types of details – explanations, examples, and a quote – to support the topic sentence.

The Joy of Having My Three Children

It is a blessing that I have three children, aged 15, 11, and 6. First, they are not lonely anymore. When I had two children, they complained to me many times. My son wanted a younger brother, and my daughter wanted a baby sister. They also fought for toys. After my third child was born, their life changed a lot. Most times, they played with her and even taught her how to use chopsticks. Now all three children are very happy together. As a result, I am delighted. However, with three children, I feel really old sometimes, but they make me feel young. Each of my children has many activities, and I am very involved in their lives. Last month, when my second child participated in a cross-country competition[9] organized by the school district, I ran next to her and cheered her on. I felt young and energetic as if I were 16 years old again. The part I love the most is that they help me become a better person. Each child has a different personality. Sometimes, I cannot understand why they act in a certain way, but I find out that they are trying to imitate[10] my husband and me. "Children are mirrors of their parents". This saying is so true. I can see my own problem through them because their action reflects my behavior. Now I am more careful when they are around. I do not yell, I do not judge other people, and I always say "Thank you". I want to set a good example for them. Even though I am often physically tired, I love them because love makes miracles happen. My children are the joy of my life.

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Exercise 2. Use two of the topic sentences you have developed from Exercise 1 to make a paragraph outline for each. Check to see that the ideas support the topic sentence.

Example:

Parts of a Paragraph	Outline Ideas
Topic sentence	Three subjects often cause disagreement between teenagers and their parents.

Question:	What are the three subjects?
Supporting Sentence 1	about friends
Details 1	Teenagers: appearance, popularity; Parents: good students, good behavior
Supporting Sentence 2	about free time
Details 2	Teenagers: games, movies, relaxing; Parents: reading, exercising, housework
Supporting Sentence 3	about school work
Details 3	Teenagers: study not the only thing, favorite subjects; Parents: study, grades, college majors

#1

Parts of a Paragraph	Outline Ideas
Topic sentence	
Question:	
Supporting Sentence 1	
Details 1	
Supporting Sentence 2	
Details 2	
Supporting Sentence 3	
Details 3	

#2

Parts of a Paragraph	Outline Ideas
Topic sentence	
Question:	
Supporting Sentence 1	
Details 1	
Supporting Sentence 2	
Details 2	
Supporting Sentence 3	
Details 3	

Exercise 3. Use Paragraph “The Joy of Having My Three Children” as an example. Add relevant information to make Paragraph “Ways to Reduce Stress” more interesting.

Ways to Reduce Stress

(Picture: a red pencil writing the word "stress")

a red pencil writing the word “stress”

Modern life creates a lot of anxieties in people, but there are different ways to control stress. Physical exercises are a common solution. **(Add some details here about how physical exercises help reduce stress.)** Another idea is talking to a friend or family member. Someone says that sharing feelings and experiences with others is like releasing at least half the burdens. **(Add some more details here about how talking helps reduce stress.)** Besides working out and sharing, doing some chores will help relieve stress for some people. Many people do not like housework, but they do not know that household work may bring a sense of calm and normalcy. **(Add some more details here about how doing chores helps reduce stress.)** Stress has become an integral part of modern life. Isn’t it time for each person to find a way to handle it?

V. Conclusion in Enumerative Paragraphs

EXERCISE

♠♠ Click here to review writing conclusion from Unit 3 Parts and Characteristics of a Good Paragraph: It usually restates the main idea but in different words or sentence structure. It usually summarizes the main points in the body of the paragraph. It usually expresses an opinion, makes a prediction, puts forth a recommendation, or asks a question related to the topic. A conclusion must not bring up a new topic.

For detailed explanations and examples of concluding sentences, open Unit 3 here.

Discuss what types of conclusion (reinstatement, summary, opinion, prediction, recommendation, and/or question) are used in the two paragraphs you have read in this unit.

- Public Laundromats in the U.S.A.:

Of course, for eight months in America, I had to use the public laundromat more than a few times because I did not have another choice. Imagine my happiness and relief when I finally bought my own first washing machine!

- The Joy of Having My Three Children:

Even though I am often physically tired, I love them because love makes miracles happen. My children are the joy of my life.

Exercise 4. Read the following paragraph. Fill in the missing information as instructed.

(Picture: a man waiting at a bus stop)

a man waiting at a bus stop

Transportation in the Suburbs

(Start the paragraph with a topic sentence here.) To begin with, the buses run very infrequently[11]. Some buses come once an hour, even during the rush hours. If people miss the bus, they will have to wait for an hour for the next one. In that case, they will be late for their work or school. Additionally, it is not healthy to wait for a long time in winter. Winters can be very harsh, with heavy snow and biting winds. People can easily catch cold. The worst part is that the buses do not cover all the areas. **(Add some details here about what inconveniences this situation may cause.**) **(Add a conclusion here to complete the paragraph.)**